cent of the Jat vote, according to the exit poll, an increase of 4 percentage points over the previous election in 2017. Despite the farmers' agitation in western UP, almost half the Jat vote went to the BJP.

So much so that the BJP did not have to ride the Hindutva rath, despite delivering on its promise to build the Ram temple in Ayodhya. That credential is now taken for granted. Nor did it see the need for communal polarisation, despite the hijab controversy in Karnataka providing a timely opportunity for exploitation in poll-bound UP.

The BJP instead concentrated its energies on a new demographic—what it called the 'laabharthi varg' or the beneficiary class that has been the recipient of the government's social schemes. Beginning January 11, it started a Laabharthi Sampark Abhiyan, an outreach programme as part of which BJP workers visited the homes of the beneficiaries falling under the 125,000 booths in the state. There, they would apply sandalwood *tika* on the beneficiaries' foreheads and paste a sticker outside their door with the words '*Mera parivar, Bhajapa parivar*' (my family is the BJP family).

Those benefits included free rations under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana. A brainchild of the Union home minister Amit Shah, it is meant to ensure that some 150 million people in the state got 5 kg of rice or wheat, 1 kg pulses, 1 litre oil, salt and sugar twice a month for free against their ration card up to March 2022. An additional 3 kg of wheat and 2 kg of rice are being given under the National Food Security Scheme. The UP CM has said he intends continuing the scheme beyond March. The measure proved to be a master stroke, eating into Mayawati's Dalit vote bank and Akhilesh Yadav's overtures to the OBCs.

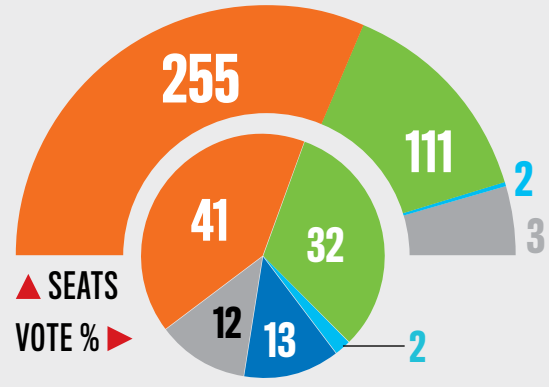
Likewise, the PM Kisan Nidhi and Ujjwala Yojanas benefit close to 39 million, or a fourth of the total voter base. Another 3.3 million people in UP are said to have availed of benefits under the PM Awas Yojana. The BJP claims that the universal coverage of these benefits helped it bridge caste and religious divisions and attract a consolidated vote. Women were another section schemes such as Ujjwala, free rations and toilets in every house targeted, helping the party earn their trust and vote. Prime Minister Narendra Modi calls them 'the silent voter' and attributed the NDA's win in Bihar in 2020 to them. More women voters seem to have backed the BJP than men—48 per cent as opposed to 44 per cent—going by the India Today-Axis My India exit poll. Female turnout also increased by 5 and 10 per cent respectively in the sixth and seventh phase of the election in UP, helping the BJP neutralise the advantage SP had acquired with caste-based alliances in these regions.

The BJP also led the narrative on how the law and order

A STAMP FOR YOGI

How UP voted in this assembly election

2022
Assembly results



TOTAL SEATS: **403**

BJP SP Congress BSP Others

HOW UP VOTED IN 2022

PHASE-WISE RESULTS

SEATS WON

BJP+ SP+ Congress Others

